

Golden Visa Quick Guide for Partners

The conversation your clients are already starting. Here's how to lead it.

Every second UK and German HNWI is asking about UAE residency right now — driven by non-dom abolition (UK, April 2025), Wegzugsteuer pressure (DE), and Box 3 changes (NL, 2026). Most advisors react. This guide puts you ahead.

Covers: eligibility, process, six mistakes that cost clients six-figure sums, tax implications by country, and ready talking points for client conversations.

Section 1: Eligibility

Property value threshold: 2,000,000 AED (~\$545,000 USD) minimum. **Eligible property types:**

- Completed residential property (ready, not off-plan)
- Off-plan property if purchased from approved developers and at least 50% paid
- Land with construction project approval
- Property purchased through mortgage (value = purchase price, not equity)

Timeline:

- Application submission: within 6 months of property registration
- Processing: 6-8 weeks from complete document submission
- Visa validity: 10 years, renewable

Dependents included:

- Spouse
- Unmarried children (no age limit if financially dependent or studying)
- Parents (if main applicant has minimum 15,000 AED/month income)

Key requirement: Property must be retained throughout visa validity. Sale triggers visa cancellation unless replaced with equivalent property.

Section 2: The Process (Step-by-Step)

Week 0-2: Property selection and pre-screen

- WTP conducts banking eligibility check (critical: can client open UAE bank account?)
- Property selection aligned to Golden Visa requirements
- Structure advisory: personal ownership vs. company ownership (tax implications vary by country)

Week 2-3: Property purchase

- Sale and Purchase Agreement (SPA) signed
- Deposit transferred to escrow (typically 10%)
- Mortgage pre-approval if applicable

Week 3-4: Transaction close

- Full payment, DLD (Dubai Land Department) registration
- Title deed issued
- For off-plan: Oqood certificate (interim registration)

Week 4-6: Visa application

- Document preparation: title deed, passport copies, Emirates ID application, proof of relationship for dependents
- Medical fitness test and Emirates ID biometrics
- Application submission through approved channels

Week 6-8: Visa issuance

- Approval received
- Entry permit issued
- Visa stamping in passport
- Emirates ID card delivery (within 2 weeks)

Total timeline: 6-8 weeks from property purchase to visa in hand (assuming no complications).

Section 3: Common Mistakes

Mistake 1: Buying before bank pre-check

- Problem: Client purchases 2M AED property, then discovers no bank will open account for SOF reasons.
- Result: Property owner without banking infrastructure, cannot transfer funds in/out efficiently.
- WTP approach: Banking pre-screen BEFORE property search.

Mistake 2: Wrong ownership structure

- Problem: UK client buys in personal name, triggers UK tax reporting. German client structures through offshore company, creates Wegzugsteuer complications.
- Result: Unintended tax exposure, compliance burden, potential penalties.
- WTP approach: Structure advisory based on client's home jurisdiction tax rules.

Mistake 3: Insufficient SOF documentation

- Problem: Client has purchase funds but cannot document clean source trail.
- Result: Visa approved but banking rejected, or prolonged account opening (6+ months).
- WTP approach: SOF assessment during pre-screen, document preparation roadmap before transaction.

Mistake 4: Choosing non-eligible off-plan

- Problem: Not all developers qualify for Golden Visa via off-plan route.
- Result: Client pays 50%+, discovers property doesn't qualify, must wait for completion (2-3 years).
- WTP approach: Developer eligibility verification before SPA.

Mistake 5: Ignoring exit tax in home country

- Problem: DE client relocates to UAE via Golden Visa but doesn't structure exit properly, triggers 30-40% Wegzugsteuer on unrealized gains.
- Result: UAE move costs more than tax saved.
- WTP approach: Partner coordination — you handle exit tax, we handle UAE entry structure.

Mistake 6: Buying property "too cheap" for banking

- Problem: 2M AED property in secondary market area doesn't signal wealth to UAE banks (they prefer 3M+ AED or prime locations).
 - Result: Account opening delays, multiple rejections.
 - WTP approach: Banking scenario modeling — if SOF requires premium profile, we recommend 3M+ AED property in prime area.
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Section 4: Tax Implications by Country

UK (Non-Dom Changes)

- From April 2025: Non-dom regime abolished, replaced with 4-year FIG (Foreign Income and Gains) regime.

- UAE Golden Visa establishes tax residency in UAE (if 183+ days/year physically present).
- Double Tax Treaty UK-UAE: rental income from UK property taxed in UK, can be exempt in UAE if structured correctly.
- CGT on UK property: payable even if UAE tax resident. Exit planning critical before relocation.
- Advisory need: Coordinate with UK tax advisor on timing of relocation, CGT structuring, trust unwinding.

Germany (Wegzugsteuer — Exit Tax)

- Exit tax triggered: if shareholding >1% in any company and relocation outside EU/EEA.
- Tax: 25% on unrealized gains at departure (can be deferred if move to EU, not UAE).
- Golden Visa does NOT exempt from Wegzugsteuer.
- Structuring: Must handle BEFORE move. Options: realize gains before exit, corporate restructuring, or accept payment.
- Advisory need: Exit tax calculation, restructuring options, timing of property purchase relative to exit.

Netherlands (Box 3 Changes)

- From 2026: Box 3 shifts to actual returns (vs. deemed return), but high effective tax on savings/investments.
- UAE tax residency: Requires 183+ days in UAE + deregistration from BRP (Dutch municipal register).
- Golden Visa route: Establish UAE residency, demonstrate center of life shift, apply for Dutch non-residency.
- Property structuring: Personal vs. BV (Dutch company) ownership has different tax treatment on exit.
- Advisory need: Dutch deregistration process, Box 3 exit planning, treaty benefits.

Switzerland

- Varies by canton. Wealth tax burden drives relocation.
- Golden Visa: Establishes UAE residency for treaty purposes.
- Exit: Cantonal exit tax on departure (if applicable), coordination with Swiss advisor critical.
- Banking: Swiss clients often retain Swiss accounts — WTP coordinates UAE account as secondary, not primary.

General principle across jurisdictions:

- Golden Visa = tool for UAE residency, NOT automatic tax optimization.
- Each country has specific exit rules — partner must coordinate exit, WTP coordinates entry.
- Best outcome: Partner handles home country exit structuring, WTP handles UAE banking + visa + property + substance setup.

Section 5: WTP Value-Add (What We Do That Agents Don't)

WHAT TYPICAL AGENTS DO	WHAT WTP DOES
Show properties, negotiate price	Banking pre-screen BEFORE property selection
Close transaction, hand over keys	Structure advisory: personal vs. company ownership based on tax jurisdiction
Submit visa application	SOF preparation roadmap, bank selection matched to client profile
Limited post-sale support	Ongoing retainer: renewals, compliance, property management, substance advisory
Focus: commission from sale	Focus: integrated setup (property is part of investor infrastructure, not standalone)

Specific WTP advantages:

1. **Banking-first approach** — We reverse-engineer: start with "can this client open account?", then select property and structure.
2. **Structure expertise** — Personal name? UAE company? Offshore holding? Each has banking and tax implications. We model scenarios.
3. **Visa processing** — In-house, not outsourced. Direct relationship with typing centers and GDRFA.
4. **Compliance substance** — If client needs to prove UAE substance for home country tax, we build it: office lease, utility bills, residence history, UAE bank statements.
5. **Partner coordination** — We don't replace tax advisors. We execute UAE side while you handle home jurisdiction exit.

Example integrated case:

- UK client, non-dom ending, £5M liquid assets, wants UAE Golden Visa.
 - Partner handles: UK CGT planning, trust restructuring, exit timing.
 - WTP handles: Banking pre-screen → 3M AED property in Dubai Marina → company setup for holding structure → UAE bank account → Golden Visa → tax residency certificate → ongoing retainer.
 - Result: Client exits UK cleanly, enters UAE with working infrastructure, retains advisor relationship.
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Section 6: Talking Points (Ready Phrases for Client Conversations)

When client asks: "Should I buy property in Dubai for Golden Visa?"

"That's a viable path for UAE residency, but the property decision should come AFTER we verify banking eligibility and tax structuring. I work with an execution partner in UAE who checks bankability first — most buyers discover account issues after purchase, which defeats the purpose. Let me coordinate a pre-screen, then we'll know if property route works for your situation."

When client asks: "How long does it take?"

"Golden Visa processing is 6-8 weeks once property is registered. But the full timeline depends on banking complexity and your home country exit planning. My UAE partner handles the property and visa side — I'll coordinate the exit tax piece on this end. Realistic end-to-end: 3-4 months from decision to visa in hand, if we structure it correctly from the start."

When client asks: "Can I buy off-plan to get Golden Visa faster?"

"Technically yes, if the developer is approved and you've paid 50%+. But there's a banking risk: you commit funds before account infrastructure is in place. My recommendation: let's run a banking pre-screen first. If that works, we proceed with ready property for faster execution, or off-plan if the developer qualifies and banking scenario is solid."

When client asks: "Do I need to live in UAE full-time?"

"For tax residency recognition in most countries, you need 183 days/year physically present in UAE. For visa validity, you just need to enter UAE once every 180 days. The requirement depends on your tax goal. If you're exiting [UK/DE/NL] tax residency, you'll need the 183 days. If it's just a residency option, the 180-day entry is enough. I can coordinate with my UAE partner to structure substance requirements based on what your home jurisdiction requires."

When client asks: "What if I sell the property later?"

"Golden Visa is tied to property ownership. If you sell, visa is canceled unless you replace with equivalent property (2M AED+) within 6 months. This is why structure matters: buying in personal name vs. company name affects exit flexibility. My UAE partner models scenarios — personal ownership is simpler for visa, company ownership may have advantages for your [UK/DE/NL] tax situation. Let's structure it right from the start."

When client asks: "Can your UAE partner handle everything?"

"They handle UAE execution: property, banking, visa, compliance. I stay involved for tax coordination on your home jurisdiction side. You'll work with both of us — I'm your advisor, they're the operator. All communication flows through me unless you prefer direct contact. The partnership is documented with client protection terms, so your relationship with me remains primary."

Summary Checklist for Partner

Before recommending Golden Visa route to a client, verify:

- [] Client has 2M+ AED (~\$545K USD) liquid and documentable funds
- [] SOF is clean and traceable (no high-risk jurisdictions, crypto is <30% of total, employment/business income documented)
- [] Client's home country exit tax implications are understood (especially DE Wegzugsteuer, UK CGT)
- [] Client understands 183-day requirement if seeking tax residency recognition
- [] Banking pre-screen completed BEFORE property search
- [] Structure (personal vs. company ownership) aligned with client's tax situation

If all checked, proceed with WTP pilot case submission. If any red flags, address them before property commitment.

What Happens When You Don't Pre-Screen

Real scenario (anonymized): German entrepreneur, 45, €4M liquid. Purchased 3.5M AED apartment in Downtown Dubai through a local agent. Applied for Golden Visa — approved in 6 weeks. Applied for bank account — declined by 3 banks over 4 months. Reason: complex multi-entity SOF involving crypto conversion and Maltese holding structure. Property paid, visa active, no working bank account. Eventually opened account at a tier-2 bank with significant restrictions. Total delay: 5 months. Additional advisory costs to restructure SOF narrative: ~\$15,000. **With WTP pre-screen:** Banking complexity identified in 48 hours. SOF roadmap prepared before property commitment. Bank selected based on client profile. Account opened 3 weeks after property purchase. The difference: sequence.

Start with one case. Free pre-screen, zero obligation.

Send client profile → receive banking verdict + service plan in 48 hours.

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